

Female hormones

Hormones are chemicals produced in the body that send instructions to cells. Each hormone can only affect specific target cells, which contain the appropriate receptor for that hormone.

SEE ALSO

◀ 28–29 What is puberty?

Changing body

32–33 ▶

The menstrual cycle

36–37 ▶

Breasts

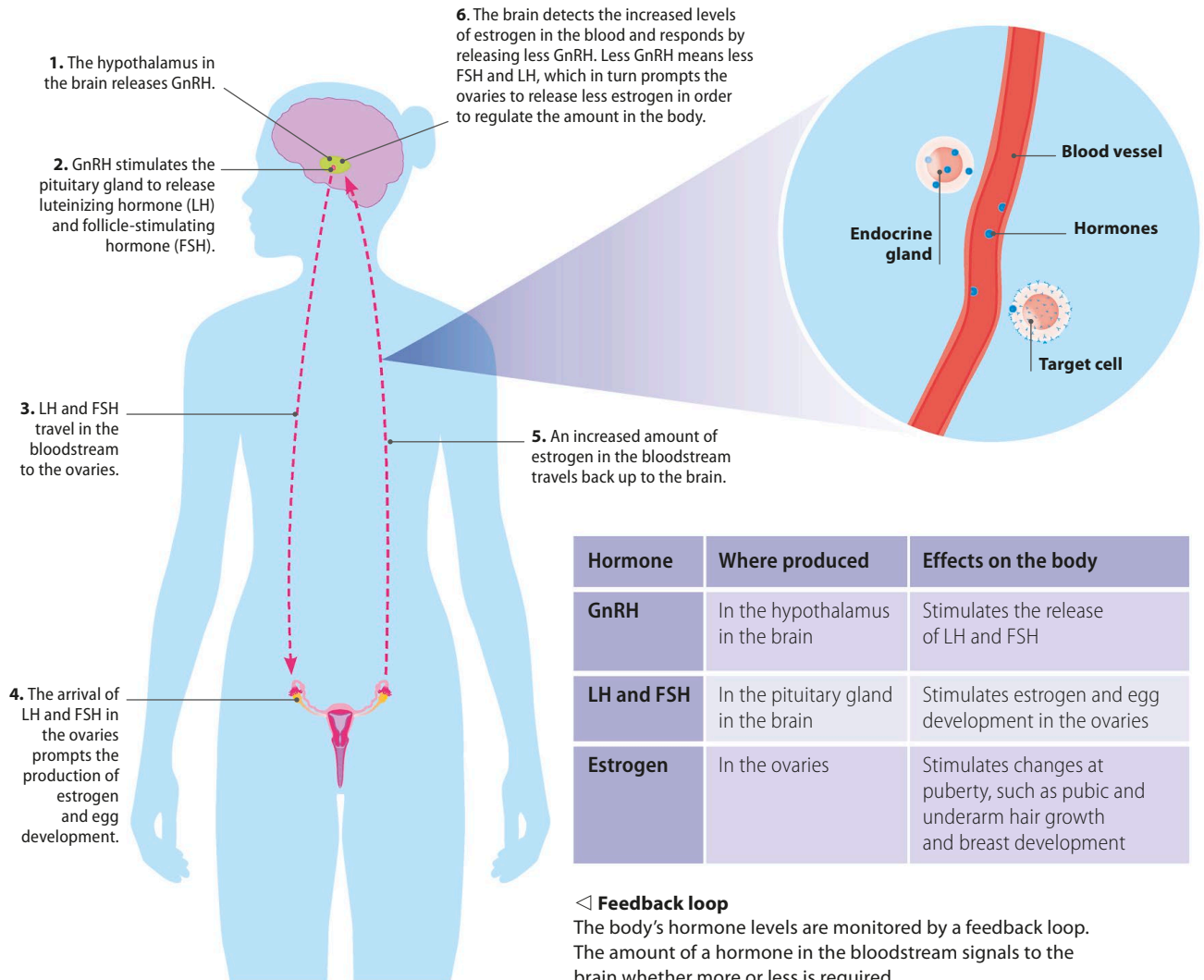
40–41 ▶

Kickstarting puberty

At the start of puberty, gonadotropin-releasing hormone (GnRH) in the brain signals to the body that it's ready to start developing into an adult. GnRH causes an increase in the level of the primary sex hormones in females and males—estrogen in females, and testosterone in males. As puberty continues, these and other hormones regulate and monitor each stage of development.

▽ Chemical messengers

Blood vessels transport hormones from the endocrine glands to specific cells around the body, where they stimulate change.



◁ Feedback loop

The body's hormone levels are monitored by a feedback loop. The amount of a hormone in the bloodstream signals to the brain whether more or less is required.